these two countries, marking, as it did, a level of recognition of the Soviet government by Britain that it had never previously admitted.[1] Some have argued that the accord represented a turning point, not only in Britain's policy towards Russia, but in its perspective on its foreign relations in general – a move from the militaristic frame of mind that had dominated Britain's immediate post-war foreign policy, to a peacetime mentality.[2] The continued attempts in those years to curb military expenditure certainly support this argument. However, others have argued that the trade agreement in no way represented a change in the actual attitude of the British government. Instead, the diplomatic manoeuvres involved in the trade negotiations 'in political terms represented a continuation of the military intervention of the immediate post-revolutionary period'.[3]

However, what is interesting is not only this debate as to what the agreement meant for Anglo-Russian relations in general, but also what the agreement tells us about Britain's imperial outlook in this period, for as has been demonstrated throughout this work, the problem of Bolshevism was inextricably linked with the issues of pan-Islamism and Asian nationalism when it came to Britain's imperial interests. The connection between Britain's relations with Soviet Russia and with that of Persia and Afghanistan is clear, even from the terms of the trade agreement. While the document was supposed to be concerned with trade relations, the preamble required both parties to refrain from any hostile undertakings against the other (including, importantly, conducting propaganda). Accompanying the agreement, moreover, was a letter from the British government to the Soviet government, detailing the current areas in which Bolshevik subversive activity was being conducted and demanding this be stopped.[4] In September 1921, when a note was sent to the Soviet government protesting against alleged violations of the trade agreement, the examples cited were that of Bolshevik sedition towards India and within Persia and Afghanistan.[5] Hence, when it came to Russia, Persia and Afghanistan (or Bolshevism, Islamism and nationalism), the three were hard for Britain to separate in the post-war period.

In fact, the trade agreement was not the only accord to be signed that year. Indeed, 1921 could be termed the year of the treaty. For, Moscow would sign agreements with the governments of Afghanistan, Persia, Turkey and,